

SIERRA ASCENT

Master Expedition Report | 4-Day, 3-Night Loop Itinerary

Santa Ana ➔ Burney Falls ➔ Lake Tahoe ➔ Sequoia National Park ➔ Kings Canyon ➔ Santa Ana

~1,300 mi	115 ft → 6,225 ft	6 L / person	Hotels
TOTAL LOOP DISTANCE	ELEVATION RANGE	WATER REQUIRED	NIGHTLY LODGING

Departure: Friday, July 4, 2026 @ 12:00 AM (Midnight Thursday) | Return: Monday, July 7, 2026 @ ~5:30 PM

DAY 1 · THE CASCADE LAUNCH & TAHOE ARRIVAL

Friday, July 4

12:00 AM

Depart Santa Ana

Leave at midnight Thursday night and drive straight up I-5 North through the quiet Central Valley.

10:00 AM

Burney Falls

Stretch your legs on the flat paved trail around the roaring 129-foot wall of spring-fed water.

Note: A pre-booked 2026 day-use parking reservation is required for holiday weekend entry.

1:30 PM

Depart for Lake Tahoe

Drive south along scenic Lassen corridors to Lake Tahoe (about 2.5 hours).

4:00 PM

Check in — Lake Tahoe

Settle into your resort base. Unwind, enjoy dinner lakeside, and rest up after the midnight haul.

DAY 2 · THE ULTIMATE TAHOE SHOWCASE

Saturday, July 5

8:00 AM

Sand Harbor State Park

Arrive early to claim beach territory. Explore the crystal-clear turquoise waters and smooth granite boulders.

11:30 AM

Secret Cove Beach

Take the peaceful ~1-mile round-trip trail down to this hidden cove with Caribbean-like water colors.

2:00 PM

Emerald Bay & Eagle Falls

Walk the breathtaking Emerald Bay overlook and grab a hearty mountain lunch, then hike the scenic, rushing Eagle Falls trail.

Note: Eagle Falls can be heavily congested on holiday weekends — allow an extra 2 hours for parking/traffic.

7:30 PM

Cave Rock Sunset Scramble

Finish the day with a short but steep rocky scramble to watch the sun drop behind the Sierra peaks from 180 degrees up.

DAY 3 · THE GREAT REDWOOD CROSSING & SEQUOIA NIGHT

Sunday, July 6

8:30 AM

Depart Lake Tahoe

Drive south through the Sierra passes to Sequoia National Park (about 5 hours).

2:00 PM

Kaweah River & Redwoods

Cool off after the long drive with a refreshing swim in the emerald Kaweah River swimming holes. Climb the handrail-assisted staircase of Moro Rock and stand beneath the colossal General Sherman Tree.

Evening

Check in — Sequoia Area

Settle into your local Sequoia hotel for the night.

Cold weather warning: temperatures plummet once the sun dips beneath the giant forest canopy. Dry off completely after swimming and shift directly into warm hoodies, fleeces, and pants to avoid hypothermia risk.

DAY 4 · THE KINGS CANYON GRAND FINALE & RETURN

Monday, July 7

8:00 AM

Drive to Kings Canyon

Head directly to neighboring Kings Canyon National Park, only about 30 miles from Sequoia's northern gates.

9:00 AM

General Grant Tree & Zumwalt Meadow

Visit the majestic General Grant Tree, celebrated as the "Nation's Christmas Tree." Take a crisp, peaceful morning walk through Zumwalt Meadow along the scenic boardwalk next to the canyon cliffs and rushing Kings River.

12:00 PM

Lunch & Drive Home

Have lunch in the park or foothill gateways, then begin the drive south back to Southern California via CA-99 and I-5 (about 5 hours / 290 miles).

5:30 PM

Arrive — Santa Ana

Welcome home! Your complete Sierra loop is complete.

PACKING & SAFETY CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Water:** 6 liters of reusable water capacity per person (mandatory)
- ☐ **Sunscreen & bug spray:** individual responsibility — everyone packs their own
- ☐ **First-aid kit:** supplied and managed by the trip organizer
- ☐ **Warm layers:** fleece/hoodie/pants for freezing Sequoia evenings — no sleeping bags needed since you're in hotels
- ☐ **Swim gear:** for Sand Harbor, Secret Cove, and the Kaweah River — dry off fully before sunset on Day 3 to prevent hypothermia
- ☐ **Reservations:** 2026 Burney Falls day-use parking permit booked in advance

Sierra Ascent · Santa Ana to the Sierra Nevada and back · July 4–7, 2026